

L-R, CMs Himanta Biswa Sarma, Mamata Banerjee, M.K. Stalin and Pinarayi Vijayan

BATTLE OF THE CHIEFTAINS

One a veteran, another a fiery fighter, the third a political scion who has proved his mettle, and the fourth a master of the political game. The coming assembly elections are a contest of towering personalities, each commanding an arena of national import. In West Bengal, Mamata Banerjee, seeking a fourth consecutive term, faces a high-stakes battle against the BJP, which sees the state as the last unclaimed big prize in its eastern kitty. In Kerala, the stakes for Pinarayi Vijayan are existential: a defeat could write the political epitaph of not just the octogenarian CM but also of the Left, giving the Congress power in three out of five states in the South. The contests in Tamil Nadu and Assam are about consolidation. A return to power would cement the standing of M.K. Stalin and Himanta Biswa Sarma, turning electoral victory into enduring political capital. In the following pages, we analyse each chieftain's prospects and challenges.

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